



How to Write a Meaningful Thank You Letter

BY RABBI BORUCH ALTEIN

THE MERE THOUGHT OF SITTING DOWN, PEN AND PAPER IN HAND, TO FINISH WRITING A LONG LIST OF OVERDUE THANK YOU NOTES CAN BE QUITE OVERWHELMING. READ ON TO DISCOVER WHY EXPRESSING GRATITUDE IN WRITING IS IMPORTANT, AS WELL AS HOW YOU CAN TURN THIS OFTEN DAUNTING TASK INTO AN EASILY ACCOMPLISHED ACTIVITY THAT IS NOT ONLY MEANINGFUL TO THE PERSON RECEIVING THE LETTER, BUT TO YOU AS WELL.

Why is it important to write thank you letters?

A thank you letter conveys gratitude to someone who, out of his own good will, expended effort to assist you in some way. Though expressing verbal thanks is important, communicating your appreciation in writing makes your sentiments become far more tangible to the recipient of the letter.

Additionally, while thank you letters should be viewed as an end in and of themselves, the fact is that a thank you letter that conveys the significance of the gift and what it has accomplished causes the giver to feel good about what he or she has done and serves as a stepping stone to a lasting relationship and future gifts. Though the initial gift may be small, properly acknowledging it may very well serve as the beginning of a lifelong connection.

Who deserves a thank you letter?

Anyone who's done you a good turn, whether with money, resources, time or effort, deserves to be acknowledged. Every monetary or in-kind donation, no matter how small, calls for a thank you letter. It may sometimes be hard to decide which gifts of time and effort qualify for thank you letters so it's always best to err on the side of caution. After all, you can never go wrong by making someone feel appreciated and extra good.

What to include in a thank you letter

Thank you letters should be comprised of the following five components:

Personal greeting: Begin by addressing your donor with the appropriate personal title. Use "Dear Joe" or "Dear Mr. Freeman" instead of the generic "Dear Friend." (Greet the person with the name you'd use if speaking to him or her face-to-face.)

Statement of thanks: Convey your appreciation for the gift, specifying what the gift accomplished.

"Thank you for your generous donation of \$200. Your gift helped pay for the delicious food and drinks that were served at the Purim party."

Instead of: *"Thank you for your \$200 donation to Chabad."*

Explanation: Describe why the gift is significant. Be sure to associate the accomplishment with the donor, rather than with yourself or others.

"There are many people in our community who cannot afford to pay the suggested donation. It is thanks to you that we were able to welcome them with open arms and still cover all the expenses."

Instead of: *"Chabad is so important to the future of the Jewish nation."*

Closing statement: End off by reiterating your sincere thanks.

"We are grateful that you have chosen to partner with us

Sample Thank You Letter

Can you spot each of the components and "small details" described in the article within this letter?

Dear Michael,

Thank you very much for your recent donation of \$200 to our Hebrew school. Your generous gift helps Emily, Michelle, Jordan, David and nearly 20 other young Jewish children discover their rich Jewish heritage in a child-focused, safe and dynamic environment. Your recent gift, together with your previous donations to our Hebrew school, demonstrate your staunch support of Jewish education in our town and your commitment to ensuring Jewish continuity. I am personally inspired by your dedication. Thank you, once again, for your donation and partnership.

With warm wishes for the best of success in all your endeavors,



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P.S. Feel free to browse through photos of our Hebrew school students in action at www.hebrewschool.com.

and appreciate your support.

Instead of: *We appreciate your donation and hope you will support us once again soon.*

Signature: The letter should be hand-signed by the most prominent figure in the mosad. Preface with words that convey your blessings and emotions.

“With wishes for the best of success in all your endeavors,” “Wishing you good health and all the best,” “With friendship,” or *“Sincerely”* are but some examples.

Questions to Ask Yourself While Writing

Answering these questions will help you determine whether your letter is on track.

Is this letter donor-centric?

Be sure to emphasize what the donor has accomplished, rather than what the organization has accomplished, and thank him for being who he is.

Is this letter clear and easy to understand?

Short, simple, emotionally appealing letters are best.

Does this letter convey enthusiasm and a can-do approach?

Even when discussing serious matters, present them positively. Everyone likes being part of success, while no one wants to support a losing cause.

Does this letter demand more from the donor?

Asking the donor to donate again or fill out a survey demonstrates a lack of respect for the donor and the fact that he has already given of his time, resources or money.

Small Details That Make a Big Difference

Express emotion: To make it easier to do so, picture yourself thanking the donor in person and then jot down the words you'd say.

Put pen to paper: In today's digitized age, a handwritten thank you letter tells a person you really care and is more meaningful than it ever has been. Sure, it can't be done to scale, but is certainly apropos when someone gives a significant gift. Nice stationery is a plus!

Check your spelling: Avoid all typos and errors—especially in the donor's name!

Change up your templates:

Is it alright to schedule my letter writing for a later date and rely on the automatic receipt for now?

While a receipt is important, it is a completely different animal than a thank you letter and cannot become a replacement. If you'd like your thank you letter to convey sincerity, it must come very soon after the gift has been given. (Additionally, if you wait too long, the giver will have forgotten he's even donated.) In order to achieve maximum impact, experts suggest that thank you letters be given within two days of receiving the donation. If that's too high a bar, try to do it within a week.

Customize your letter templates for fit each occasion.

Keep it brief: Two paragraphs is the longest a thank you letter should be.

Provide contact information:

Give the donor a way to follow up with any questions he may have. You can also provide a website or other means through which the donor can further his connection to you (not the donation page!).

Reference previous gifts: If the donor has given to you in the past, try to mention the gift and what it has accomplished. The more significant the gift, the more important it is to do so. 

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How to Increase the Effectiveness of Your Emails

